in conceptualizing or designing the NDB, or even the African Regional Centre. South Africa's relatively subdued role in establishing the new financial institutions was at least partly a consequence of increasingly public clashes between Zuma and his more fiscally conservative finance minister, Nhlanhla Nene. Nene, a traditional banker, had angered the president by cutting Treasury subsidies in early 2015 to the country's loss-making flagship carrier, South African Airlines, run by a close friend of the president; as well as openly disagreeing with him about the economic viability of developing nuclear energy. When Zuma abruptly fired Nene in December 2015, replacing him with a little-known ANC back bencher, a financial panic ensued, exacerbating a fall in the rand, which already had lost about a quarter of its value since July.[282] After ten days, appointment of a second and more experienced finance minister, Pravin Gordhan, calmed the markets. Although the government quickly announced that it intended to nominate Nene for a senior position to the NDB's African Regional Centre, when Nene was interviewed two months later, he told the reporter that he had not yet heard anything official and was "keeping busy by tending his garden."[283] In the end, Nene was not nominated, and he has gone on to work in the private sector. In early 2017, increasingly public infighting between the ANC's more pro-market faction and the populist president led Zuma to fire Gordhan at the end of March.

Nonetheless, the Zuma government's choices for the South African appointments to the NDB have been well received, although the president is deeply unpopular with much of the business community.[284] Leslie Maasdorp, senior private banker and former head of Southern Africa operations for Bank of America, became South African vice president of the NDB, and former Reserve Bank of South Africa Governor Tito Mboweni joined the new bank's Board of Directors. The two have embraced their new roles with enthusiasm. For instance, Maasdrop, as the NDB's new chief financial officer (CFO), quickly began making the rounds of what international investors term the dog-and-pony show circuit, giving presentations and answering questions for institutional and individual investors, who are expected to purchase the new bank's bonds and thus to provide the bulk of its loan funds, while the five countries' sovereign contributions provide the paid-in and callable capital, or the bank's essential ballast.[285]